monarchy and in favour of a more democratic and representative government.[42] And it was not difficult for RAW to reinforce the idea that the chogyal had to go. Even the ethnic composition of Sikkim was heavily against the old monarchy. According to the 1971 census, the Nepalese formed an overwhelming majority of 134,000, with the Lepchas numbering only 25,000, and the Bhutias along with the related Tsongs made up about 23,000.[43]

Although achieved without military intervention, Sikkim could be seen the second major success achieved by India's security services. The first was scored during the much more violent creation of Bangladesh in 1971. India supported the freedom struggle launched by the Mukti Bahini fighters who wanted East Pakistan to break away and form an independent country, and RAW saw here a golden opportunity to secure the country's eastern frontiers, including the strategically important Siliguri Neck and the Sikkim corridor to the Tibetan frontier.

After the Indian intervention in the war, *The Sunday Times* of London reported in its 12 December 1971 issue, 'It took only 12 days for the Indian Army to smash through on its way to Dacca [Dhaka], an achievement reminiscent of the German *Blitzkrieg* across France in 1940. The strategy was the same—speed, ferocity, and flexibility.'[44] On 16 December, the Pakistan Army surrendered and, under international pressure, on 8 January 1972 Pakistan was forced to release the leader of the freedom struggle, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman, who had been arrested in March 1971 and flown to West Pakistan, where he was kept in solitary confinement. Now, he returned in a plane provided by the British Royal Air Force to Dhaka, where a million people were waiting to greet him. East Pakistan had finally become the independent nation of Bangladesh.

The Bangladesh operation also helped New Delhi's security services locate and apprehend insurgent leaders from India's northeast who were based in Dhaka. Among them were Thinoselie Medom Keyho, who, together with Thuingaleng Muivah, had led the first Naga mission to China in 1967 and Neidelie, another member of the top leadership of the Naga National Council (NNC). The Mizo rebel chief Laldenga, who was also based in Dhaka at the time, managed to escape along with several of his men across the border to Myanmar. He later made it to Karachi in Pakistan